

Researcher vs. Red Guard Dialogue

Round 1

Witness:

You call it “a revolutionary act.” That phrase makes my stomach turn. I still hear the teacher screaming, and I still see the way you held her down. The clipper snagged and tore, and she cried like an animal in a trap. You did not stop. You did not even look away.

And I remember something small that people never put in books: afterward, her hands kept going up to her head, like she was trying to cover what you did. She could not even meet anyone’s eyes. That was the point, wasn’t it? To make her smaller.

RedGuard:

You are right. Her hands. The way she tried to hide. I remember hair stuck to her neck, and someone behind me laughing. I did tell myself “revolutionary act” because that made it easier. But if I say it honestly, part of it was also proving myself. I wanted to look hard. I wanted to be seen. If I hesitated, the others would say I was weak or “soft-hearted.”

I am not saying that to excuse it. I am saying it because it is ugly and true: I cared more about how I looked than about her pain.

Witness:

So you admit it was also about showing off. Good. Because people keep pretending it was only “the times.” It was also choices.

And you know what makes me angry? You remember details clearly. The hair stuck to her neck, the laughter behind you. That means you knew exactly what you were doing. You knew it was cruel, and you did it anyway.

Round 2

Witness:

When you say you wanted to be seen, I think about the hospital. The way you arrived like you owned the place. The gate blocked, guards posted, people forced to line up. It was not a “meeting.” It was a trap.

That nurse you humiliated, she did not die because she was “weak.” She died because you left her no way back into being a person. I saw her after the parade, sitting stiff, not speaking, like her body was still on the street with the placard. Later that night, she hanged herself.

And you just said you panicked about who would be blamed. That is what I cannot swallow. While someone is dead, your first thought was your own safety.

RedGuard:

Yes. That is what my first thought was. You are right to call it out. I remember the sound in the corridor when someone shouted that she was found. It was like the air turned cold. I did not go upstairs to see her. I stayed where I was. I told myself “leaders will handle it.” That is another lie people like me used. We hid behind the word “leaders” the way we hid behind “revolution.”

And about the hospital, it did feel like a trap. We had a list. We knew the names before we even stepped in. Some staff inside were eager, like they had been waiting for permission. We fed off that.

You said she had no way back into being a person. Hearing you say it like that, I cannot argue. That is exactly what public shaming does.

Witness:

Do not turn it into theory. “Public shaming does.” You did. You and your hands and your mouth and your armband.

And you know what else I remember? Not just the parade. Afterward people went home and acted normal, like cooking dinner while someone’s life was collapsing. That ordinary calm around cruelty is what still makes me feel sick.

Round 3

Witness:

You keep saying “I told myself” and “we hid behind words.” But there were moments you did not need words. You had the crowd. You had the heat of the bonfire. You had people jeering.

I stood in that crowd once. Not cheering. Just frozen. The smell of burning paper and cloth, ash landing on shoulders, the targets forced to stand there for hours. It was like watching someone be erased while still breathing.

And what stayed after was not “history.” It was daily life poisoned. Doors closed faster. Conversations got shorter. Children learned to copy cruelty like it was a game. Even now, when someone knocks at night, my body reacts before my mind does. That is not ideology. That is damage.

RedGuard:

When you say your body reacts before your mind, I believe you. Because I have my own

version, and I hate admitting it. Sometimes a sudden shout in a crowd still makes me tense, because I remember being the one who shouted.

You are right that words were not always needed. Sometimes it was just the feeling: people stepping aside when we walked, doors opening, faces lowering. I liked that. I am not proud of it, but I liked it. That is why it is not enough for me to say "I was fed ideology." I also tasted power.

And the bonfire, I remember the heat on my face too. At the time I thought it was purification. Now I remember the targets blinking hard because of the smoke, trying not to cough, trying not to move.

You said you were frozen in the crowd. I was not frozen. I was moving. I was making it happen. That difference is the part I cannot smooth over.

Witness:

Good. Do not smooth it over.

Because if you leave it as "we were swept up," you make it sound clean, like weather. This was not weather. This was people deciding, again and again, to hurt someone and then go eat dinner.

And I am telling you plainly: I do not want your comfort. I want you to sit with the fact that you were not just present. You were an actor.

TERMINATE